before dawn and working while everyone was still sleeping.

“Good morning,” Édouard addressed them. “Today we finish the harvest. I can’t thank you both enough.”

“Rose, you go ahead,” Léa said. “I’ll join you outside shortly.”

Rose nodded, lifting the overalls and a hat from the peg on the wall. She went outside and hauled a basket up the slope to the vines. What did Léa want to speak with Édouard about in private again? Was Léa keeping secrets from her?

The yellow-green grapes glistened with the morning dew, and Rose thought of the still life by Heda. She would never be able to recreate that light without color. Maybe it had been wrong not to stand up to Madame Martin to get her pastels back. And then she thought of André. Though she didn’t speak of him, he was always present, like a bit of light inside her, keeping her company during the long hours of bending over the vine trunks to pick the grapes. She could hear his voice and feel the warmth of his breath on her neck. A flicker of doubt crossed her mind—was it foolish to cling to these memories? When would she see him again? More than anything, she wanted to know that he was safe.

Léa walked up the slope. Rose could see by how she held her arms tight to her sides that something was on her mind. Rose wished that Léa would stop trying to protect her from the truth. But Léa set about picking the grapes and didn’t say a word.

By the time the sun was high in the sky they’d both finished an entire row. When the church bell rang the noon hour, they took a break, drinking water and eating cheese. Rose tried to get her sister to talk a little.

“Is everything all right?” Rose asked.

“Yes.”

“You look tense, not like your usual self.”

“I’m fine. Let’s get back to work.”

Rose’s fingers ached from holding the cutters in her palm all morning but when she snipped the final cluster off the vine a few hours later, she raised her hands in the air and shouted, “I’m done.”

“Bravo,” Léa said.

At that moment, Paulette came out of the farmhouse carrying a basket overflowing with items. The sisters looked at one another and smiled.

“I completely forgot,” Rose said.